

University of Oregon AI Policy Report

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A Report by

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for WR320 at UO



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Introduction



Generative artificial intelligence (AI) became commonplace in education following its widespread availability in the early 2020s.

While adaptation to AI is an ongoing challenge, university policy has yet to address the important ethical issues surrounding AI use and academic integrity.

The focus of this report is to explore how academic AI policies can be refined to promote ethical, consistent, and enforceable guidelines for both students and instructors.

Purpose

This report synthesizes current University of Oregon AI policy with peer university policies, and proposes AI policy improvements. This report is based on research surrounding the impact AI has on student learning outcomes.

Audience

The Office of Student Conduct and Community Standards (SCCS) sets the precedent for student behavior at UO and adjudicates student code violations. Their mission, in their own words:

“It is our responsibility to establish the community standards and procedures necessary to maintain and protect an environment conducive to learning and in keeping with the educational objectives of the University of Oregon.

We serve the important role of upholding the standards of the university community through the administration of an educational and student-centered conduct process. In this process, we educate students about self-accountability, social responsibility, and academic integrity.” ([UO](#))

Any change in policy takes place through the Student Conduct Advisory Committee (SCAS), which authors the policies of the SCCS.

Impact

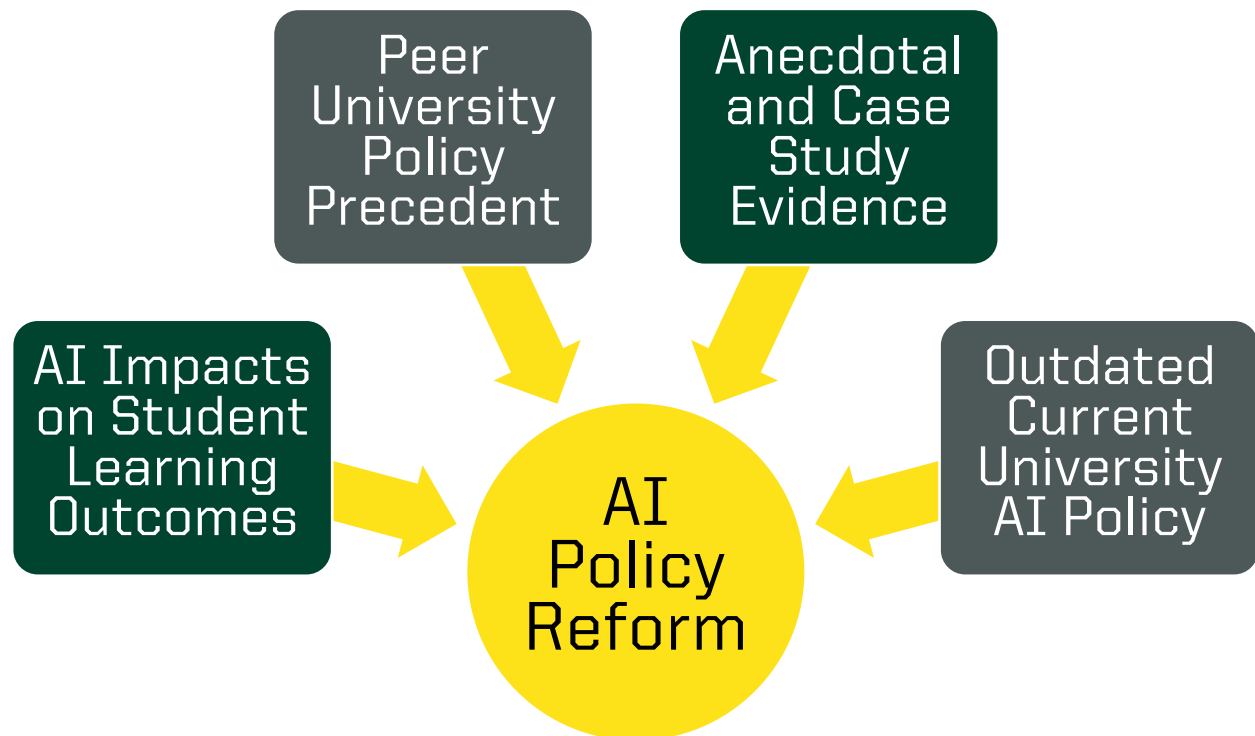
If the SCCS wants to uphold their goal of “Embark[ing] on a multi-year to update its Student Conduct Code and process that are meant to make them more specific and timelier...[sic]” ([UO](#)), changes to their AI policy will need to be made.



Several surveys have estimated 80-90% of university students use AI ([Mulford](#)). This, coupled with the fact that over half of all misconduct reports submitted to SCCS were related to AI use, shows a clear precedent of rampant AI misuse on UO campus ([UO](#)).

Methodology

This report concerns the current University of Oregon student conduct code policy. This policy considers unauthorized use of AI as plagiarism, and allows instructors to determine their own guidelines on AI use in their courses ([UO](#)). In order to address the issues with this policy, this report relies on four main sources of information: research on how AI impacts student learning outcomes, Peer University AI policies, Anecdotal and case study evidence of AI abuse and misuse, and a critical analysis of current university policy.



University AI Policy



University of Oregon Current Policy

Policy Review and Criticism

Current UO policy encourages instructors to determine their own rules and expectations for AI use.

UO Student code has been updated to include the unauthorized use of work generated by AI and other sources as plagiarism. Any student presenting material that contains content generated by AI or like sources as their own without accurate attribution is an explicit case of plagiarism ([UO](#)).

Some of the only guidelines UO provides are a few suggestions for instructors on how to either integrate or deter AI use:

Integration

- **AI Assist in Research**

Use AI to generate terms, concepts, or topics relevant to a text or idea.

- **Evaluate AI Work**

Have AI write an essay, and ask students to evaluate the work according to the assigned rubric.

- **Revise with AI**

Submit a student-written essay to an AI engine and have it create an outline. Use the AI generated outline to identify opportunities for revision.

[\(UO, Teaching Support and Innovation\)](#)

Deterrence

- **Self-Contained Material**

Create assignments based on course-specific material like lectures, discussions, handouts, or other materials not published online.

- **Personal Information**

Have students use personal experience or knowledge that relates to key topics or concepts.

- **Social Annotation Tools**

Utilizing social annotation tools like Perusall on texts.

- **Chunking Assignments**

Breaking major assignments into multiple drafts and steps.

[\(UO, Teaching Support and Innovation\)](#)

The current UO AI policy suffers from four key shortcomings:

Uncertain

Not having a central university AI policy creates uncertainty, as every instructor is expected to author their own without clear guidelines.

Unclear

Not communicating what responsible AI use is, and not requiring AI training is unclear to all.

Permissive

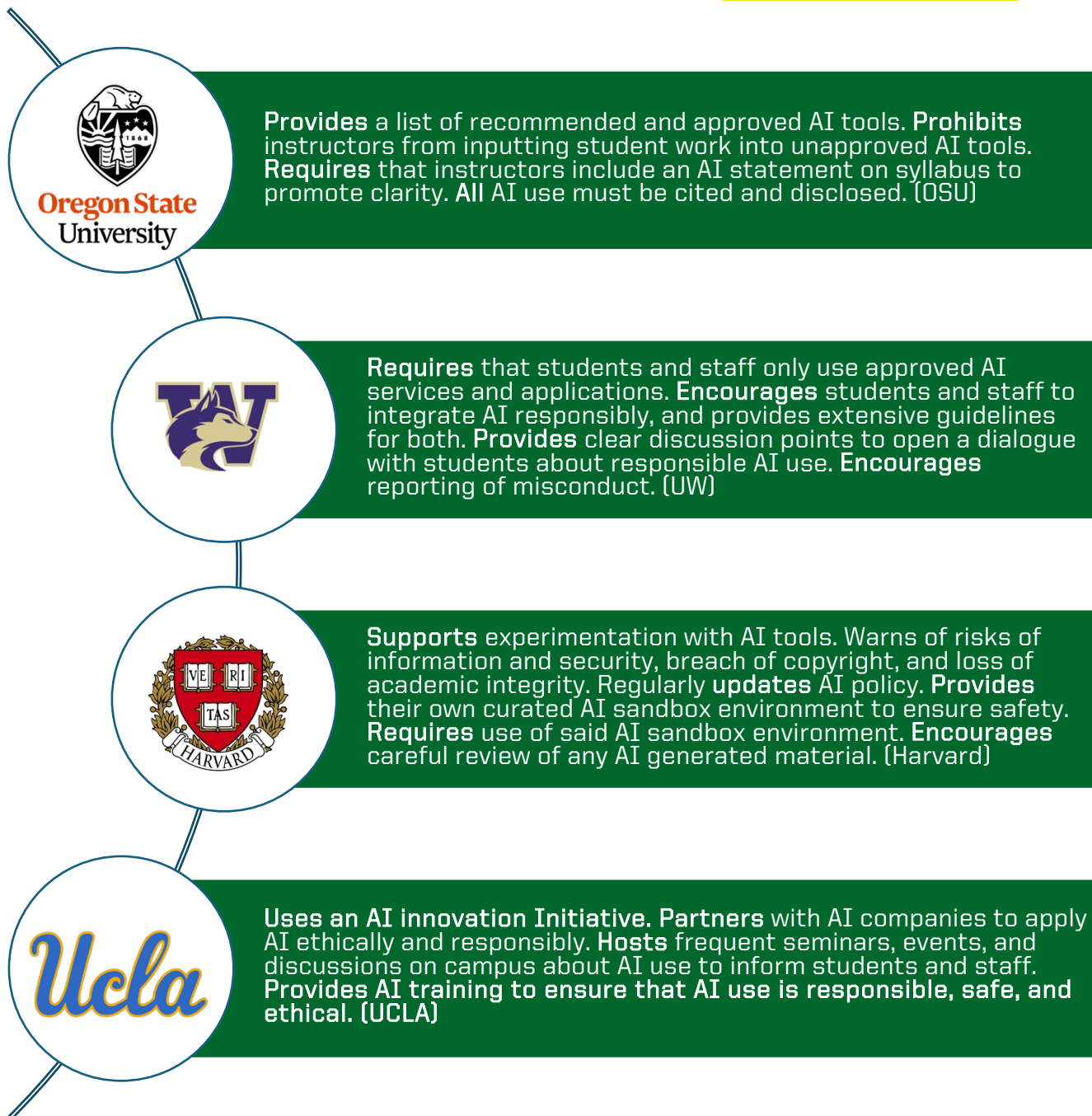
Not providing a stance either for or against AI integration creates unrestrained student use.

Unenforceable

Not having a reliable way to detect AI and no communicated consequences for misuse, allows students to cheat using AI with no risk of repercussion.

Peer University Policy Precedent

Policy Survey and Principles



Key Principles of Peer AI Policy

Emphasis on Discourse

The most common element of university AI policy is deterrence through education. Required AI trainings and frequent on-campus seminars cultivate a norm of responsible and ethical AI use.

Required Disclosure

The one element of AI use universities can control is faculty use. Many successful AI policies require instructors to include a university-written AI policy.

Required Software

Many universities have provided both students and staff with a list of safe, secure, and school-approved AI platforms to use.



The benefits of a policy that includes these facets respectively are:

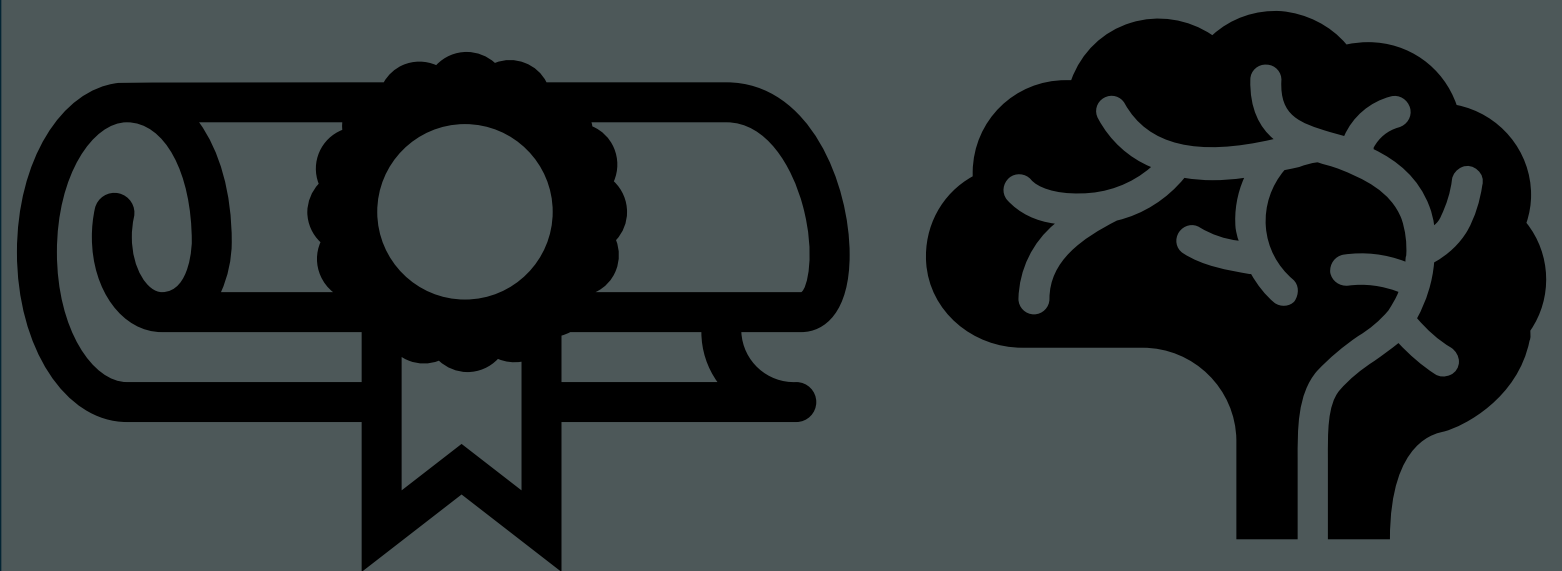
Promotion of responsible use through fundamental AI discourse

Increased ethicality and online safety

More consistency and clarity for both students and staff

While enforceability remains an issue for every university, helping students understand the loss of their academic integrity through AI use is vital ([Aaron](#)).

AI and Learning Outcomes



AI Use: Rates and Impact

Campus Culture and Data

“As it stands right now, our systems don’t accomplish either of those goals. We don’t fully lean into AI and teach how to best use it, and we don’t fully prohibit it to keep it from interfering with exercises in critical thinking. We’re at an awkward middle ground where nobody knows what to do, where very few people in power even understand that something is wrong.”

-Owen Kichizo Terry

From [*UO Artificial Intelligence Resource Guide*](#) (as of writing)

Several studies have estimated AI usage rates in university students as between 80-90% (Contactor, 10).



The hands-off approach of UO’s AI policy shifts the burden of responsible AI use onto students and educators. Without guidance, students aren’t held to strict standards of use.



AI policy impacts classroom culture; many university students use AI without disclosure, because there is no anticipated consequence for submitting AI work.

On the other side of the spectrum, professors often face frustration when they see work that has clear signs of AI use, but have no way to effectively prove it was used.

Impact on Learning Outcomes

AI can be used to automate work, or to augment learning ([Contractor, 14](#)). Every AI policy should be structured around encouraging augmentation over automation

Automation

- AI produces fully-formed outputs that can be submitted with minimal student input ([Contractor, 14](#)).

Augmentation

- AI is used to enhance human capabilities. Tasks like proof-reading, searching for sources, minor editing ([Contractor, 14](#)).

Not all AI use is inherently harmful for student learning. There is no simple way to achieve responsible AI use, but three factors are very clear.

1. Students and staff deserve more explicit guidelines and rules for AI use.
2. Not all students use AI to avoid learning.
3. University policy cannot fully prohibit or fully allow AI use.

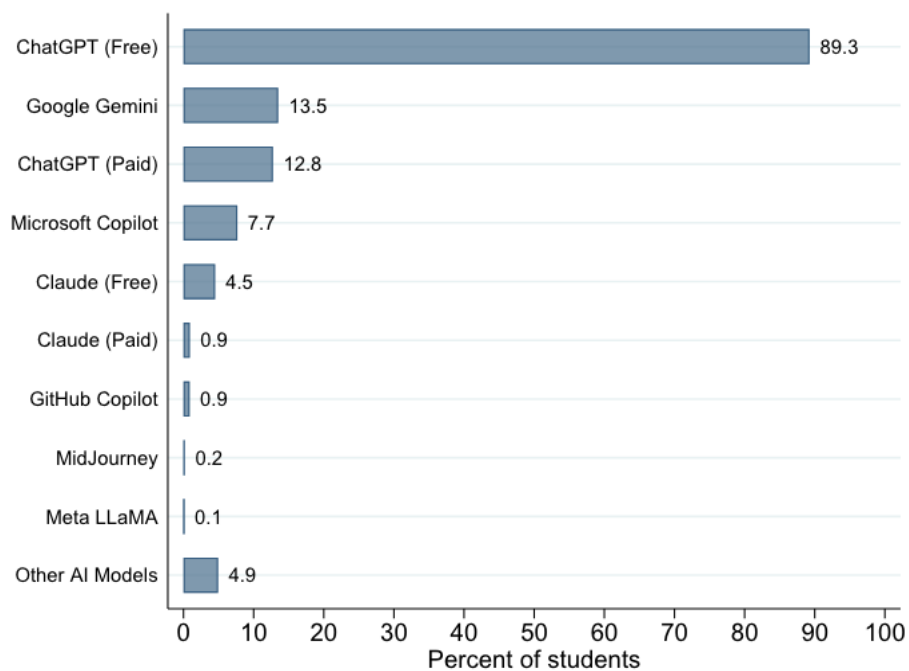
AI should **always** be supplemented with detailed guidance and flexible application strategies ([Hu, 11](#)).

“It is imperative to address AI in education *now* to realize key opportunities, prevent and mitigate emergent risks, and tackle unintended consequences”

– [U.S. Department of Education](#)

Trend of Misuse

There is a disconnection between recommended AI guidelines and actual AI use. Many successful AI policies include a list of recommended AI platforms. The concern is that a majority of students don't use school-suggested AI tools.



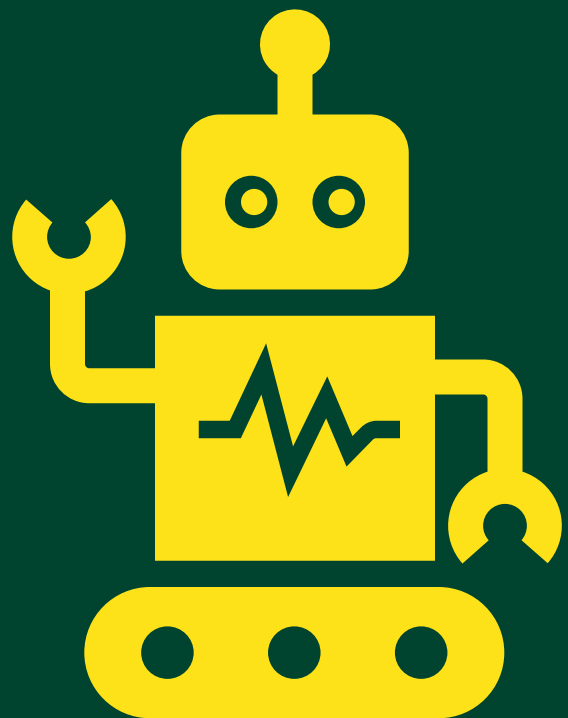
“Adoption of Generative AI Models Among College Students”

([Contractor](#), 28)

This data suggests that without comprehensive guidance and accessible university AI tools, students will trend toward using less safe and reliable options like ChatGPT.

The culture of “solution-seeking behavior” causes students to overestimate their abilities and underperform in their learning outcomes ([Lehmann](#), 7).

Student and Expert Opinions



Student Opinion: My Experience

Anecdotes and Reflection

Notetaking

It is possible for students to effectively record and summarize their lectures with no human input. I have seen students using an AI notetaker while performing unrelated tasks, or leaving the room entirely.

Essay Writing

One of the most problematic uses of AI I have seen is the automation of writing tasks. From full essays to group presentations, many of my peers openly admit to running course prompts through AI engines to produce full essays. Students will simply reword the essay into their own voice before submission.

Article Reading

AI article summarization is the most appealing, and therefore most widespread application of AI I have seen. AI can turn hours of reading into a few minutes of straightforward synopsis and analysis. AI summarization has been integrated directly into search engines and archives. While summarization saves time, the amount of information lost, neglected, or misinterpreted poses a threat to learning outcomes.

Student Takeaways

AI use is more widespread than data can reflect. Research into the impacts of AI is struggling to keep up with the evolution of AI technology. It is important to implement AI policy that functions pragmatically, and keeps the interest of student learning above all else.

AI tools can circumvent a dangerous amount of coursework. Students can complete discussion posts, quizzes, essays, presentations, even entire examinations in seconds.

Regardless of how difficult AI policy may be to write, it is needed to protect the integrity and value of education as a whole.

Despite my own ethical opposition to the use of AI, I still advocate for the AI integration that causes the least harm to our educational systems.



Matilda

Expert Opinion: Educators

Opinions and Takeaways

“Finally, AI systems are here to stay and like calculators and computers they will radically change how people work in the near future. Education needs to evolve and teach students how to use AI responsibly and effectively... Perhaps, instead of hunting down AI use, we should be teaching it to our students. Certainly, students still need to learn fundamentals, but they also need to learn how to use these powerful tools.”

-James O'Brien, Professor of Computer Science, [UC Berkeley](#)

“If we direct students to AI writing tools for some learning purpose, we should teach critical AI literacy at the same time. We can emphasize that language models are statistical predictors of word sequences; there is no understanding or intent behind their outputs. But warning students about the mistakes that result from this lack of understanding is not enough.”

-Anna Mills, English Instructor, [College of Marin](#)

“I think everybody is cheating ... I mean, it's happening. So what I'm asking students to do is just be honest with me. Tell me what they use ChatGPT for, tell me what they used as prompts to get it to do what they want, and that's all I'm asking from them... I don't think human nature changes as a result of ChatGPT. I think capability did.”

-Ethan Mollick, Associate Professor, [UP Wharton](#)

Expert Takeaways

AI is an inevitability of our future. The future of ethical AI use lies on the shoulders of everyone involved.

AI Literacy should be at the heart of our efforts. The advent of new technology is full of opportunity, but it needs to be approached systematically.



Students need to be incentivized to learn *through* AI, not replacing their learning with AI.

AI use needs to be addressed as soon as possible in educational settings. Misuse can rob students of their learning outcomes.

Sloane

Recommendations and Conclusions



Policy Changes

Best Practices

We can draw on peer university policy, as well as educator and student opinions to identify key features of successful policy.

Certainty

The University of Oregon should require all educators to include a specific, centralized AI use guideline in their syllabus. Mandatory usage of school-approved AI tools will also ensure the safety of anyone who uses AI.

Clarity

The University of Oregon should implement and make mandatory a set of guiding principles for AI use, including AI literacy and ethics. If students and staff are trained on AI literacy they will understand the consequences of AI use.

Futureproofing

The University of Oregon should take a less permissive stance on AI use. Since prohibiting AI outright is an untenable solution, AI literacy programs must be implemented as soon as possible. UO has the resources to implement trainings, but has yet to do so.

Enforceability

The University of Oregon should clearly outline rules for responsible AI use, creating opportunity to identify and punish AI misuse. If students use to learn AI as a resource instead of a solution, they are less likely to abuse it.

Conclusions

The evidence is clear that the SCCS's current AI policy does not adequately support students' learning outcomes. Students are robbing themselves of their education and coming out the other side overconfident in their abilities. If UO continues passively allowing all AI guidelines to be written course-by-course, students will complete their education with varying, and at times dangerous understandings of AI literacy and use.

Despite my personal belief that AI tools are disrupting vulnerable communities and causing irreparable harm to our planet and society, I understand that other people will always choose to use them. UO policy should leave students with the tools to use AI responsibly.

AI is a tool that far exceeds the capabilities of humans in one category alone: output. When entire courses can be run through a chrome tab and passed, the value of our education is threatened. Once we come to terms with the reality that is AI and choose to educate our students and staff to use AI responsibly will we be protecting learning outcomes.

Meaningful change begins with UO administration. We need widespread changes: AI literacy courses, reevaluated guidelines, consistent enforcement, and open dialogue. To preserve the value of our education, the SCCS should consider implementation of this proposed policy update.

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